

Animals whose screams are categorically ignored and silenced

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(Rosemary-Claire, “Apocalypse Meow”, *Capitalism Nature Socialism*, 24:1, 35-41, dml)

<https://www.cnsjournal.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/09/Collard.24.1.13.pdf> //claire rc

“A true political space,” writes Swyngedouw (2010b, 194), **“is always a space of contestation for those who are not-all, who are uncoun- ted and unnamed.”** This true political space necessarily **includes***if only by virtue of their exclusion*animals, the “constitutive outside” of humanity itself. How we respond to this dynamic ought to be a central question of critical scholarship and philosophizing. To be a philosopher, says Deleuze in the “A for Animal” entry to the “abecedary” (*L’abécédaire* de Gilles Deleuze 1989), **“is to write in the place of animals that die.”** This is still an **imperfect** way of describing my objective (for one thing, I am also interested in animals that are still alive), but it is an improvement over being a “spokesperson” for animals, which are often characterized as speechless and may be rendered more so having spokespeople appointed to speak on their behalf. To write in the place of animals that die seems a **preferable**, though still fraught, **characterization**.

This paper **is** therefore **written** in the place of those uncoun- ted and unnamed non-subjects of political space, the animals that die, the nonhumans, **the hundreds of millions of animals that are “living out our nightmares”** (Raffles 2010, 120): **injected, tested, prodded, then discarded**. We have denied, disavowed, and misunderstood animals. **They are refused speech, reason, morality, emotion, clothing, shelter, mourning, culture, lying, lying about lying, gifting, laughing, crying*the list has no limit. But “who was born first, before the names?”** Derrida (2008, 18) asks. **“Which one saw the other come to this place, so long ago? Who will have been the first occupant? Who the subject? Who has remained the despot, for so long now?”** Some see identifying this denial as a side-event, inconsequential, even sort of silly. The **belief in human superiority is firmly lodged** and dear to people’s hearts and senses of themselves. It also seems a daunting task, not a simple matter of inserting the excluded into **the dominant political order**, which as Žižek (1999) writes, **neglects how these very subversions and exclusions** are the order’s condition of being.

The existence of othered animals is the root cause of violence

[Erica Saboya, [Erica Saboya is a researcher and environmental journalist who specializes in animal rights, environmental issues, and the relationship between humans and nonhuman animals.] "The dehumanization of animals", October 26, 2023,

<https://sumauma.com/en/a-desumanizacao-dos-animais-2/>] //claire+adam

"We are fighting human animals and we are acting accordingly," declared Israel's defense minister, Yoav Gallant, in an attempt to justify the unjustifiable: cutting off water, electricity, gas, and food to the people of the Gaza Strip, after Israeli civilians were massacred by the terrorist group Hamas. **Similar phrases are heard again and again** by correspondents covering the Middle East war, which might be called a massacre, given the disproportionate force that has been used against civilians in Israel and Palestine at another. As the Folha de S.Paulo journalist Yan Boechat has written, **the other is an "animal," someone who can no longer be seen as "human."** Although it is obligatory to note the huge difference between an authority publicly calling another group of people **"animals,"** the common-sense word chosen **to name the other,** whether Israeli or Palestinian, **exemplifies** what many columnists around the world **are defining** as the **"dehumanization" of those who are** ethnically or racially different. **the root of genocides throughout history.** As an example, take the genocide of the Tutsi people in Rwanda after Hutu radio and newspapers launched a campaign to "kill the cockroaches,". More than 500,000 Tutsis were killed in 100 days. **By treating the other as an "animal," extermination is** apparently **justified by** some people. **Promoting dehumanization is enough to authorize slaughter.** This **mutual dehumanization is** perhaps **the only** explicit **consensus** between Israel's extreme right, led by Benjamin Netanyahu, and the leaders of Hamas. **For both sides, the only way out is to wipe the other not just out of the territory, but out of life – and this is why the violence against civilian populations is supposedly legitimate.** But is this about dehumanization? From a Euro-centric perspective, without a doubt it is. Nevertheless, it's worth daring to think based on other philosophical traditions, which **challenge anthropocentrism – centered on human beings.** For example, "creatures are people" for most native peoples in the Americas. Humanity is seen from the vantagepoint of the person looking at it. This means that to themselves, animals are humans. It is impossible to explain something so complex in an editorial – for a deeper look at this idea, I suggest diving into the fascinating concept of "Amerindian perspectivism," as devised by anthropologists Eduardo Viveiros de Castro and Tânia Stolze based on the knowledge of different native peoples. Therefore, what we all share would not be "animality," but rather "humanities." **This vision** is evident in myths, which evoke a time when different beings communicated and recognized each other as reciprocally human. It **is** not a mere inversion, but **a radical displacement of colonizing thought.** **This different way of understanding worlds and understanding each other within worlds has led to an existence that makes it possible to live with everyone else without annihilating the common home,** what is now called the climate crisis by non-Indigenous activists, while shamans like Davi Kopenawa, of the Yanomami people, call it the "Earth's revenge."

Differences shouldn't determine moral equality, including IQ -- same observation applies to racism/sexism

Peter Singer, No Date, [Peter Singer is a prominent philosopher and leading scholar of animal ethics and utilitarianism, making him qualified to assess the moral consideration of animals.] "All Animals Are Equal", No Publication, DOA 2-6-2024, <https://spot.colorado.edu/~heathwoo/phil1200,Spr07/singer.pdf> // claire + BL

A **liberation** movement **demand an expansion of** our **moral horizons and an extension** or reinterpretation **of the basic moral principle of equality.** Practices that were previously regarded as natural and inevitable come to be seen as the result of an unjustifiable prejudice. Who can say with confidence that all his or her attitudes and practices are beyond criticism? If we wish to avoid being numbered amongst the oppressors, we must be prepared to re-think even our most fundamental attitudes. We need to consider them from the point of view of those most disadvantaged by our attitudes, and the practices that follow from these attitudes. If we can make this unaccustomed mental switch we may discover a pattern in our attitudes and practices that consistently operates so as to benefit one group—usually the one to which we ourselves belong—at the expense of another. In this way we may come to see that there is a case for a new liberation movement. My aim is to advocate that we make this mental switch in respect of our attitudes and practices towards a very large group of beings: members of species other than our own—or, as we popularly though misleadingly call them, animals. In other words, **I am urging that we extend to other species the basic principle of equality** that most of us recognize should be extended to all members of our own species. All this may sound a little far-fetched, more like a parody of other liberation movements than a serious objective. In fact, in the past the idea of "The Rights of Animals" really has been

used to parody the case for women's rights. When Mary Wollstonecraft, a forerunner of later feminists, published her *Vindication of the Rights of Women* in 1792, her ideas were widely regarded as absurd, and they were satirized in an anonymous publication entitled *A Vindication of the Rights of Brutes*. The author of this satire (actually Thomas Taylor, a distinguished Cambridge philosopher) tried to refute Wollstonecraft's reasonings by showing that they could be carried one stage further. If sound when applied to women, why should the arguments not be applied to dogs, cats, and horses? They seemed to hold equally well for these "brutes"; yet to hold that brutes had rights was manifestly absurd; therefore the reasoning by which this conclusion had been reached must be unsound, and if unsound when applied to brutes, it must also be unsound when applied to women, since the very same arguments had been used in each case. One way in which we might reply to this argument is by saying that the case for equality between men and women cannot validly be extended to nonhuman animals. Women have a right to vote, for instance, because they are just as capable of making rational decisions as men are; dogs, on the other hand, are incapable of understanding the significance of voting, so they cannot have the right to vote. There are many other obvious ways in which men and women resemble each other closely, while humans and other animals differ greatly. So, it might be said, men and women are similar beings and should have equal rights, while humans and nonhumans are different and should not have equal rights. The thought behind this reply to Taylor's analogy

is correct up to a point, but it does not go far enough. There are important **differences between humans and other animals**, and these differences

must give rise to some differences in the rights that each have. Recognizing this obvious fact, however, **is no barrier to the case for extending** the basic principle

of **equality to nonhuman animals**. The differences that exist between men and women are equally undeniable, and the supporters of Women's Liberation are aware that these differences may give rise to different rights. Many feminists hold that women have the right to an abortion on request. It does not follow that since these same people are campaigning for equality between men and women they must support the right of men to have abortions too. Since a man cannot have an abortion, it is meaningless to talk of his right to have one. Since a pig can't vote, it is meaningless to talk of its right to vote. There is no reason why either Women's Liberation or Animal Liberation should get involved in such nonsense. The extension of the basic principle of equality from one group to another does not imply that we must treat both groups in exactly the same way, or grant exactly the same rights to both groups. Whether we should do so will depend on the nature of the members of the two groups. The basic principle of equality, I shall argue, is equality of consideration; and equal consideration for different beings may lead to different treatment and different rights. So there is a different way of replying to Taylor's attempt to parody Wollstonecraft's arguments, a way which does not deny the differences between humans and nonhumans, but goes more deeply into the question of equality and concludes by finding nothing absurd in the idea that the basic principle of equality applies to so-called "brutes." I believe that we reach this conclusion if we examine the basis on which our opposition to discrimination on grounds of race or sex ultimately rests. We will then

see that we would be on shaky ground if we were to demand equality for blacks, women, and other groups of oppressed humans while denying equal consideration to nonhumans. **When we say that all human beings**, whatever their race, creed, or sex, **are equal, what is it that we are asserting?** Those who wish to

defend a hierarchical, inequalitarian society have often pointed out that by whatever test we choose, it simply is not true that all humans are equal. **Like it or not, we must**

face the fact that humans come in different shapes and sizes; they come with differing **moral capacities**, differing **intellectual**

abilities, differing **amounts of benevolent feeling and sensitivity to the needs of others**, differing **abilities to**

communicate effectively, and differing capacities to experience pleasure and pain. In short, **if the demand**

for equality were based on the actual equality of all human beings, we would have to stop demanding

equality. It would be an unjustifiable demand. Still, one might cling to the view that the demand for equality among human beings is based on the actual equality of the different races

and sexes. **Although humans differ** as individuals **in various ways**, there are no differences between the races and sexes as such. **From the mere**

fact that a person is black, or a woman, we cannot infer anything else about that person. This, it may

be said, is what is wrong with racism and sexism. The white racist claims that whites are superior to blacks, but this is false—although there are differences between individuals, some blacks are superior to some whites in all of the capacities and abilities that could conceivably be relevant. The opponent of sexism would say the same: a person's sex is no guide to his or her abilities, and this is why it is unjustifiable to discriminate on the basis of sex. This is a possible line of objection to racial and sexual discrimination. It is not, however, the way that someone really concerned about equality would choose, because taking this line could, in some circumstances, force one to accept a most inequalitarian society. The fact that humans differ as individuals, rather than as races or sexes, is a valid reply to someone who defends a hierarchical society like, say, South Africa, in which all whites are superior in status to

all blacks. The existence of **individual variations** that cut across the lines of race or sex, however, **provides us with no defense** at all **against a**

more sophisticated opponent of equality, one **who proposes that**, say, the **interests of those with I.Q. ratings**

above 100 be preferred to the interests of **those** with I.Q.s **below 100. Would a hierarchical society of this sort**

really be so much better than one based on race or sex? I think not. But if we tie the moral principle of equality to the factual

equality of the different races or sexes, taken as a whole, our opposition to racism and sexism does not provide us with any basis for objecting to this kind of Inegalitarianism. There is a second important reason why we ought not to base our opposition to racism and sexism on any kind of factual equality, even the limited kind which asserts that variations in capacities and abilities are spread evenly between the different races and sexes: we can have no absolute guarantee that these abilities and capacities really are distributed evenly, without regard to race or sex, among human beings. So far as actual abilities are concerned, there do seem to be certain measurable differences between both races and sexes. These differences do not, of course, appear in each case, but only when averages are taken. More important still, we do not yet know how much of these differences is really due to the different genetic endowments of the various races and sexes, and how much is due to environmental differences that are the result of past and continuing discrimination. Perhaps all of the important differences will eventually prove to be environmental rather than genetic. Anyone opposed to racism and sexism will certainly hope that this will be so, for it will make the task of ending discrimination a lot easier; nevertheless it would be dangerous to rest the case against racism and sexism on the belief that all significant differences are environmental in origin. The opponent of, say, racism who takes this line will be unable to avoid conceding that if differences in ability did after all prove to have some genetic connection with race, racism would in some way be defensible.

Anthropocentric policymaking lacks root solvency—it only treats symptoms because nature is valued solely as a means to human ends.

Horsthemke, 09. [Horsthemke is a professor in the Wits School of Education at the University of the Witwatersrand specializing in environmental education.] Serial No.59) US-China Education Review. P O Wits,

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The world (Africa in particular) is in a progressive state of environmental crisis, caused by global warming, loss of biodiversity, human overpopulation, pollution, massive deforestation and desertification, urbanization and many other environmental problems and risk factors. For several commentators and theorists, part of the solution resides in the provision of pertinent and adequate education, including environmental education. The present paper briefly examines the history of environmental education, internationally and in South Africa, and some of its most prominent current trends and issues, before critiquing its general orientation. Arguing against what appears to lie at the heart of environmental education and literacy, namely anthropocentrism (ideas like “education for sustainable development”), the paper urges a radical rethinking of its central concerns and *modus operandi*, in terms of facilitating learning for the natural environment. **In other words, in order to live up to its promise of contributing towards life beyond the twenty-first century, such learning must include the realization that nature matters in and for itself**

Key words: anthropocentrism; biocentrism; environmental education; sustainable development; sustainable

Use it isn't pollution that's harming the environment. It's the impurities in our air and water that are doing it. —George W. Bush
Quite frankly, teachers are the only profession that teach our children. —George W. Bush

The world was not given to you by your parents, it was lent to you by your children.—Kenyan proverb

1. Introduction—The state of the planet Arguably, one of **the greatest challenges—if not the greatest—facing humankind at the beginning of the 21st century is the state of our planet, and coupled with this our relationship with the natural environment.** Most, if not all, other concerns—however significant—are necessarily secondary in this regard. The human impact on the environment has been, and continues to be, enormous. **Human population growth and advances in technological abilities continue producing previously nonexistent environmental problems.** What is at stake here is nothing less than the survival of the earth in its present state, as being inhabitable, and therefore also human survival. **At the very least, it is a matter of the quality and conditions of our lives, present and future.** If this is correct, it follows that one of **the greatest priorities—perhaps the greatest—of academic research, scientific, philosophical, educational and other, should be into how to arrest and possibly reverse the present decline.**

There are difficulties, of course. The problem is not so much whether or not the diagnoses and prognoses are correct. Although doubts by certain scientists and some self-styled experts on climate change, etc. persist, both Kai Horsthemke, Ph.D., senior lecturer, Wits School of Education, University of the Witwatersrand; research fields: (African) philosophy of education, indigenous knowledge systems, animal rights, humane and environmental education. about the extent of the problem and about the 4 time available for humankind still to react; others claim that global warming may not necessarily be bad thing (Stampf, 2007; Stampf & Traufetter, 2007; Traufetter, 2007), it would appear that George W. Bush and his advisors, too, fell into this camp. Substantial questions concern the description and definition of the approaches, and human beings should adopt in

response to the environmental predicament/s. Further questions are raised about the metaphysical and ethical foundations of our concern for our planet. **Should educational policy and practice, for example, be informed by a concern for nature and the environment for the (human) purposes? Or should we teach and learn for the natural environment and for itself?** Interestingly, in their comparative study of different societies and cultures' textbooks, Boujemaa Agorram, Silvia Caravita, Adriana Valente, Daniela Luzi and Nicola Margnelli established that **the conception of the relationship of humans in respect to nature was characterized in terms of viewing humans as owners of nature and environment in opposition with humans as guests of the earth together with other living beings** (Agorram, et al., 2009, p. 30). They discovered that a fairly uniform approach to ecology and environmental problems appears to exist, irrespective of “cultural differences” (Agorram, et al., 2009, pp. 25-26).

one that contrasts anthropocentric perspectives with less (or non-) anthropocentric views—even if the treatment of “ecology (tends to be) rather superficial and incomplete” (Agorram, et al., 2009, p. 25). It is not the purpose of this paper to present an empirical account of the state of the earth. Facts around climate change, global warming, greenhouse gas emissions, extinction of species etc. are well known, and findings continue to be publicized and updated (for example, Andrew Goudie's account of the human impact on the natural environment, now in its 6th edition; Goudie, 2006. See also White, 1996; De Beer, Dreyer & Loubser, 2005; Gore, 2006; Connor, 2007). For the purpose of this introduction, the author wants to highlight briefly some of the implications for Africa, and South Africa in particular, before turning his attention to environmental education. Involved in the recent drafting of the fourth assessment report by the United Nations Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC) were Guy Midgley of the South African National Botanical Institute, Pauline Dube (University of Botswana) and Colleen Vogel (University of the Witwatersrand) (reported in Grant, 2007, p. 5). Their representative presence and participation were significant for a particular reason. Even in the judgement of global warming denialists like Josef Reichholf (Stampf & Traufetter, 2007), the prospects for Africa are dire: Africa is the most vulnerable to climate change. Southern Africa, in particular, faces imminent food and water shortages (Grant, 2007). South Africa has the third highest level of biodiversity in the world (De Beer, Dreyer & Loubser, 2005, p. 4). If, as seems to be a foregone conclusion (Reichholf, 2007), the southern part of Africa is going to “dry up”, the implications for biodiversity will be severe. Desertification and deforestation constitute substantial threats to biodiversity (De Beer, Dreyer & Loubser, 2005, p. 4). In addition, South Africa, with the strongest economy on the continent, accounts for more than half of Africa's electricity consumption while the country's cheap, dirty coal is the fuel driving development in the subcontinent. It would appear that South

Africa's obsession with a six percent growth rate is out of step with its obligation to curb greenhouse gas emissions. **It is, therefore, of the highest importance to counteract “the unreasoned use and ... wasting of natural resources, ... pollution” and “environmental degradation” and to bring about people's awakening (to) these problems** Education in general, and environmental education in particular, has a significant role in this awakening. It is also **a factor of education (for) citizenship** (Agorram, et al., 2009, p. 26). According to Pretoria academics Josef de Beer, Johann Dreyer and Callie Loubser:

24 **Education is one of the most effective catalysts of change**, according to Pretoria academics Josef de Beer, Johann Dreyer and Callie Loubser

(De Beer, Dreyer & Loubser, 2005, p. 27). Society should **undertake to educate the people of today to change their ways and to educate younger generations to have respect for nature (ibid.). Human ideologies require modification.** Anthropocentrism needs to give way to ecocentrism as the dominant view of the world. If humans are able to see themselves as part of nature, they will also respect forests (for example) as living communities, not only as resources to be exploited (De Beer, Dreyer & Loubser, 2005, p. 27). Strangely enough, no mention is made in the discussion of poverty, here as elsewhere, of the problem of overpopulation in this regard. If poverty means people cannot afford to take proper care of the environment or live an environmentally aware life, and if poverty is caused in part by overcrowding and reckless (or, at best, unthinking) procreation, it is clear where education should begin.

2. A brief history of environmental education

From a relatively simple and narrowly conceived concern for conservation or with human-environment relationships (approximately 60 years ago) to a more sophisticated interpretation or acceptance of multiple levels and layers of concern (spanning ethics, politics, culture and sociology), environmental education has become a complex professional field embracing ecological knowledge and understanding (Irwin & Lotz-Sisitka, 2005, pp. 35-36). The first phase of the more sophisticated or nuanced understanding yielded a definition of environmental education that reflected a scientific, rational, linear and developmental view of education. Later, it was replaced by one that included a stronger focus on social critique and social change (Irwin & Lotz-Sisitka, 2005, p. 37). Pat Irwin and Heila Lotz-Sisitka point out that there is early evidence of environmental education in China, India, Egypt, Greece and—according to oral records—sub-Saharan Africa (ibid.). They refer to the Industrial Revolution as the chief cause of the alienation of human beings (what about Cartesian dualism?)—which also propelled a new wave of environmental concern in Europe and America (Wordsworth, Thoreau, Darwin, Kropotkin and Audubon). The importance of an understanding of the natural environment in a child's education, long acknowledged by indigenous people the world over, was famously recognized by Rousseau, and later by Pestalozzi and Emerson. In 1874 Ernst Haeckel coined the term "ecology" ("the study of our home"—from Greek oikos: "home"), which was prominently embraced by Scottish professor of botany Patrick Geddes. Environmental education landmarks of the 20th century were Rachel Carson's book *Silent Spring* (1962) and the establishment of the International Union for the Conservation of Nature and Natural Resources (IUCN) and the World Wildlife Fund (WWF). Milestones in the development of environmental education on a global scale were the 1972 UN Conference on the Human Environment held in Stockholm, as well as the 1977 Conference on Environmental Education in Tbilisi (Georgia, then USSR) (Irwin & Lotz-Sisitka, 2005, pp. 39-40). Since the Rio Earth Summit in 1992, the development of environmental education has been widely influenced by the notions of sustainable development and, in particular, "education for sustainability", with many educators advocating that environmental education should, in fact, be focused primarily on achieving the goals of sustainable development (Irwin & Lotz-Sisitka, 2005, pp. 42-43). The notion of sustainable development, first articulated in the 1987 Brundtland Report for the World Commission on Environment and Development (WCED), has received global support. Sustainable development is defined as "development that meets the needs of present generations without compromising the ability of future generations

to meet their needs" (WCED, 1987, p. 43; Irwin & Lotz-Sisitka, 2005, pp. 43-47; Odora Hoppers, 2008, p. 29). 25 Tellingly, the spirit here is clearly anthropocentric. **Only the needs of humans (present and future) are mentioned, not the needs of nonhuman beings or the value of ecosystems and the environment. A similar spirit informs the Kenyan proverb cited at the beginning of this paper: "The world was not given to you by your parents, it was lent to you by your children"**

(Stewart, 2004, p. 137). In the African context, Catherine Odora Hoppers, indigenous knowledge systems (IKS) specialist and former University of Pretoria scholar, the relationship with, and to nature, human agency, and human solidarity, for instance, underpins the knowledge system and the human existence around it. Relationships between people hold pride of place, expressed in the various philosophies across Africa and best captured by the African concept of Ubuntu—a human-trophic philosophy ... (Odora Hoppers, 2008, p. 30). Ubuntu is an explicitly anthropocentric idea that has conceptual equivalents (botho or hunhu, to mention just two) in many other African languages and cultures. Muntu umuntu ngabantu (or motho ke motho ka batho) means "A human being is human because of other human beings", and also "I am because we are"—where "we" signals not only the collective but also (and especially) membership of the human species. Therefore, the environmental and ecological concern expressed by appeals to ubuntu, by definition, can not be a concern for the environment (the nonhuman biosphere) in and for itself. It is valued only either because human beings are part of it, or because it constitutes a (set of) resource(s) for (present or future) human beings to draw on. A significant development linked to the Rio Summit was the development of a Treaty on Environmental Education for Sustainable Societies, which was adopted at a plenary meeting by the International Forum of NGOs and Social Movements. Amongst others, the NGO forum principles emphasize "the value of indigenous knowledge and skills, and recognize the socially constructed nature of knowledge" (both of which are contentious principles; I return to this point below), as well as the need to promote cultural, linguistic and ecological diversity, principles that understandably became popular in South African environmental education processes after 1994 (Irwin & Lotz-Sisitka, 2005, pp. 44-45). While many educators agree that the agenda of sustainability should be furthered by education, some educators have begun to question the instrumental rationality adopted by much of the education for sustainability "doctrine", and the assumptions that sustainability provides an adequate conceptual framework for education (Irwin & Lotz-Sisitka, 2005, p. 46). The Environmental Education Association of South Africa (EEASA), established in 1992, was regarded with considerable suspicion. From its inception, EEASA promoted the idea that the people of southern Africa have many interests in common, particularly on environmentally related issues, than those which have often been used to create divisions

between them. Most significantly, it has argued that: **"We share one environment and the better we share it and collectively care for it, the better quality future all of us are likely to have"** (Irwin & Lotz-Sisitka, 2005, pp. 48-49). In the transformation of South Africa, following the 1994 elections, environmental issues and environmental education have become intimately entwined with human rights and social justice issues, as well as ecological and biophysical issues (Irwin & Lotz-Sisitka, 2005, p. 53). The 1995 White Paper on Education and Training set the scene for ongoing environmental education curriculum development work: "... environmental education, involving an interdisciplinary, integrated and active approach to learning, must be a vital element of all levels and programmes of the education and training system, in order to create environmentally literate and active citizens and ensure that all South Africans, present and future, enjoy a decent quality of life through the sustainable use of resources" (Department of Education, 1995, p. 18). Again, the anthropocentrism of this focus is noteworthy.

3. Education for sustainability 26 Alluding to the definition provided in the Brundtland Report (WCED, 1987), Lesley Le Grange and Callie Loubser acknowledge that the meaning of sustainable development as "development that takes place in such a way that it does not compromise the needs of future generations" (Le Grange & Loubser, 2005, p. 114) has been criticized for its anthropocentrism. Yet, they claim, **"sustainable development is not a monolithic entity, and a more nuanced**

understanding of the concept could incorporate values such as interspecies equity, e.g. that all living organisms have the right to being treated decently and to be protected from cruelty" (ibid.: for a "more nuanced understanding"; Bonnett, 2003, chapter 9; Wals, 2007). After distinguishing between two alternative conceptions of sustainable development, conservative and radical, Le Grange and Loubser

contend that these should not necessarily be seen as discrete categories but rather as opposite ends of a continuum (Le Grange & Loubser, 2005, p. 114). **It is this tension between conservation needs on the one hand and development needs on the other that constitutes the beginning of environmental education's association with sustainability** (Le Grange & Loubser, 2005, p. 115). For some, the authors

say, sustainable development is the ultimate goal of environmental education: hence the phrase "environmental education for sustainability": For others, sustainable development encompasses specific objectives that should be added to those of environmental education, thus the expression "education for environment and sustainable development". For still others, environmental education inherently includes education for sustainable development, thus rendering the distinction between the two meaningless (Le Grange & Loubser, 2005, p. 116). Le Grange and Loubser fail to interrogate critically these different conceptions. There is, clearly, a distinction between "education for the environment" and "education for sustainable development"—at least as the latter is commonly understood, that is, from an anthropocentric perspective. It comes as no surprise, then, that the authors should claim that different conceptions of environment, education and sustainability should coexist (Le Grange & Loubser, 2005, p. 117). They do acknowledge the "dangers in uncritically accepting a plethora of concepts that we use in environmental education", before reiterating their view that there should be an appreciation of the diversity of meanings and usage of the concept of sustainability, but also that such meanings should be (re)clarified within specific sites and discourses of environmental education (ibid.). Sustainability, they claim, is a polysemous concept. Its diversity of meanings should be celebrated and continuously (re)clarified ..., so that sustainability (sustainable development) becomes a reflective social process rather than a fixed idea (Le Grange & Loubser, 2005, p. 120). This strikes me as a somewhat anemic move, as trying to invoke an unfeasible compromise. Surely, this cannot mean that all meanings, uses and applications are equally valid. Some are

legitimately criticized as worth rejecting, not least because of an underlying, unargued presumption in favour of anthropocentrism. Take the study of environmental education and training the Human Sciences Research Council (HSRC) undertook in 1997, amongst the key findings of which was the following: "Definitions of environmental training had progressed from an association with nature conservation to a more people- and industry-based perspective" (Lotz-Sisitka, 2005, pp.166-167). If this constitutes progress, the future is indeed bleak. And if this definition is to be celebrated, rather than critically interrogated, it is even bleaker. While "sustainable development" and "sustainable use" are arguably oxymorons, sustainability might nonetheless be used as a benchmark, regarding our (human) impact on the planet—not taking out more than we put in, so to speak. This indicates a kind of banking model, but perhaps (in the absence of a more appropriate term) 27 "sustainability" will have to do.

4. The case against anthropocentrism

Is pollution (e.g. from coal-burning stoves) bad because children in relevant areas suffer more from asthma and chest colds than children elsewhere (De Beer, Dreyer & Loubser, 2005, p. 2)?

Or is it bad in itself? If an anthropocentric response is given, then one is unlikely ever to get beyond fighting the symptoms.

Stellenbosch philosopher and environmental ethics specialist Johan Hattingh provides a discussion of anthropocentric perspectives, in which he makes a distinction between the following value positions: ruthless development and exploitation, resource development and conservation, and wilderness preservation—for human benefits and enjoyment of unspoilt nature, recreational, aesthetic and the like (Hattingh, 2005, pp. 74-81). Although the last looks like non-anthropocentrism, the value of nature and the environment is entirely instrumental. The problem here is that their values depend entirely on human recreational and aesthetic benefits. Should human preferences change? There would be no axiological basis for concern. In

ecocentric value positions, by contrast (Hattingh, 2005, pp. 82-89), life in general and ecosystems as wholes are accorded intrinsic value—value in and of themselves, regardless of how humans can benefit from them. As humans evolved and developed, so did their values—through interaction with the land. According to Aldo Leopold, we are therefore not the sole authors of our values. The shift mapped here is one from a focus on relations between individuals (the decalogue) via that on the integration of individuals into

society (the Golden Rule) and integration of social organization to the individual (democracy) to a focus on the relation of human individuals to animals, plants and the land (Leopold's Land Ethic) (Hattingh, 2005, p. 82). In his discussion of so-called radical value positions (deep ecology, ecofeminism, social ecology, and bioregionalism—all of which might also be termed radical environmentalism), Hattingh perceives an emphasis on incisive, definitive and fundamental transformation, in order to address the root causes of our environmental problems (Hattingh, 2005, pp. 89-93).

Without fundamentally reorienting analysis, all "solutions" reproduce the same structures of exclusion they claim to resolve.

Bensimon-03 [Estela Mara Bensimon, 2003, [Estela Mara Bensimon is Dean's Professor in Educational Equity at USC Rossier School of Education and Director of the Center for Urban Education, which she founded in 1999], "Like It or Not: Feminist Critical Policy Analysis Matters", The Journal of Higher Education, <https://www.jstor.org/stable/3648276>/. //nw – accessible pdf: [Bensimon.pdf](#) !]

Anderson's critique rests on the assumption that her definition of the word "master" is everyone's definition. The meaning she ascribes to master can be gleaned in the assertions she makes, such as, "Feminists cannot reject the master's tools, and that it is a good thing too; ... increasing one's sensitivity to the nuances of the master's tools is the only way to go"; Bensimon and Marshall ... follow linguistic rules that reveal their mastery of academic ways of making meaning; ... they [fol- low] established academic protocols, ... the 'tools of critique' ... they urge upon their readers are synonymous with the master's tools, ... the challenges they offer would not make sense to other members of the profession ... if Bensimon and Marshall had not mastered some of the academic protocols handed down by men" (emphasis added). For Anderson the meaning of "master" is strictly academic; it has to do with expertise or command of the "linguistic rules" that signify one's "mastery of academic ways of making meaning" that separate the masters from the apprentices and distinguish between academic insiders and non-academics. Thus, according to Anderson, the master's tools (i.e., methods) are "nothing more than ways of apprehending the world" that have been handed down to women, presumably because these are the only ways of apprehending the world or because women academics are incapable of developing their own ways of apprehending the world. Joan Scott (1988) reminds us that "words, like the ideas and things they are meant to signify, have a history." And the history that Anderson associates with the word "master" is fundamentally different from the history that moved **Audre Lorde to declare, "The master's tools will never dismantle the master's house."**

The presumption that the master's definition is everyone's definition is precisely the kind of reasoning that leads to analyses that are faulty, partial, and distorting.

The Master's Tools Will Never Dismantle the Master's House was the title of a talk given by Audre Lorde on a panel, "The Personal and the Political," featured at the Second Sex Conference held in New York City on October 29, 1979. The title was intended as a criticism of white academic feminists who, in including black feminists only in those sessions that had something to do with race and leaving them out of topics such as existentialism, the erotic, feminist theory, etc., were in fact using the "tools of a racist patriarchy ... to examine the fruits of that same patriarchy" (Lorde, 1984, p. 98). Lorde's point was that feminist scholars have turned to the "master's tools" in order to gain acceptability and fit into the established disciplinary canons. **In contrast,**

Lorde urges us to turn the "differences" that are the mark of marginalized populations into strengths.

She goes on to For the master's tools will never dismantle the master's house. They may allow us temporarily to beat him at his own game, but they will never enable us to bring about genuine change.

And this fact is only threatening to those women who still define the master's house as their only source of support. (Lorde, 1984, p. 99).

For black people the term "master" is embedded in a horrific history of legalized injustice and violence. It connotes the control of one person over another or others based on skin color. Master is associated with the institutions of slavery. It is also associated with masculine representations such as the "man who serves as head of a household" or a "male teacher," as for example, in Anderson's conception of male academics handing down methods to feminist academics. Standpoint feminism helps us expand on Lorde's use of the term master and its relevance to the project of feminist and critical policy analysis. Feminist standpoint theorists make a case for the view from the bottom, "the slave," as the more complete one. "The point of departure for standpoint feminist epistemology is the idea that knowledge is socially situated. It follows that in order to interpret and understand the situation of a particular group of people, thought has to start from their lives. **Es- sentially, standpoint feminist epistemology urges us to move away from**

the idea of simply adding the "other" to preexisting frameworks and directs us to ground knowledge on the particular experience of the people we want to understand" (Lorde, 1984, p. 144).

Accordingly, standpoint feminists reject the "master's" view because it is partial and distorting. **It is partial because it is derived from a vision of reality that takes into account only the reality of the dominant class or power holders. It is distorting because it tends to normalize the experience of the "master" as the generic experience.**

In contrast, Audre Lorde urges us "to stand alone, unpopular and sometimes reviled ... to take our differences and make them strengths" (Lorde, 1984, p. 112). Similarly, standpoint feminists suggest that the position of "outsider within" (Hill Collins, 1986) and "borderline" position (Anzaldua, 1987) provide a vision of the academy and relations within it that are inverse to the master's view (Harding, 1991; Hartsock, 1983). For example, Patricia Hill Collins argues that it is the awareness of her marginal status as the "outsider within" that provides the black female intellectual with a unique black feminist standpoint from which to analyze life in the academy. **She observes, "It is the "outsider**

within" who is more likely to challenge the knowledge claims of insiders, to acknowledge the discrepancy between insiders' accounts of human behavior and her own experiences and to identify anomalies" (Fonow & Cook, 1991, p. 3). **As black feminists make clear, to accept the master's tools could be self-destructive because it would require us to adopt theories and methods-the tools- that historically have excluded women or devalued them.** Lorde's dictum, in the words of Joan Scott, warns us to not be "drawn into the very assumptions of the very discourse we ought to question" (Scott, 1998, p. 36). **To adopt the master's tools is to become an**

insider and assimilate what we described in our work as androcentric perspectives. "But," Anderson asks, "what makes those disciplines and their methods androcentric?" But, we wonder, why ask a question that Anderson herself so clearly answers? How else, other than androcentrism, could we describe the presumption that academic man handed down to us the "academic protocols" that enable our work to be understood and heard? The implication is that fitting in is contingent on compliance with his rules.

Wipeout

Harris '99 [John; December; Sir David Alliance Professor of Bioethics and Research Director at the Centre for Social Ethics and Policy and Director of the Institute of Medicine Law and Bioethics at the University of Manchester; Kennedy Institute of Ethics Journal, "The Concept of the Person and the Value of Life," vol 9, no. 4] //bm

Some people have attempted to overcome, or rather side-step, this problem by simply stipulating that it is human beings that matter (see Warnock 1983). Although this move certainly avoids the problem, it does so at some cost. **It is difficult to imagine how one would defend a moral theory that was founded on the stipulation of an arbitrary (and totally unjustified) preference for one kind of creature over another,** particularly when this preference is asserted by self-interested individuals on behalf of their own kind. **We are all too familiar with the sordid and disreputable history of similar claims in which the moral priority and superiority of "our own kind" has been asserted on behalf of Greeks at the expense of barbarians, whites**

over blacks, Nazis over Jews, and men over women. Simply stipulating arbitrarily the superiority of our own kind, whether defined by species membership, race, gender, nationality, religion, or any other nonmoral characteristic is, and has always been, disreputable. Membership of a natural kind, or of an ethnic, religious or other grouping, is not of itself a moral property. Potentiality

The problem is to distinguish in some morally significant respect, human embryos from the embryos and indeed the adult members of any other species. Species membership is not enough because human embryos seem not to differ, except in species membership and in one other feature that I will discuss in a moment, from the embryos and indeed adult members of other species. Unlike adult members of many other species they are not conscious, although they may become so at some stage during their development. The one thing human embryos have that members of other species do not is their potential not simply to be born and to be human, but to become the sort of complex, intelligent, self-conscious, multifaceted creatures typical of the human species. There are, however, two fatal difficulties for the potentiality argument. Two Problems with Potentiality The logical difficulty. The logical difficulty is straightforward but telling. We are asked to accept that human embryos or fetuses are persons, morally important beings whose interests trump those of other sorts of beings, in virtue of their potential to become another sort of being. But it does not follow logically, even if we accept that we are required to treat 'x' in certain ways, and even if 'a' will inevitably become 'x,' that we must treat 'a' as if it had become 'x,' at a time or at a stage prior to its having become 'x'. This is a rather cumbersome and inelegant way of making the point that acorns are not oak trees, nor eggs omelettes. Anyone reading this essay shares with its author one very important, inescapable potential. [End Page 297] We are both potentially dead, however, I hope neither of us is required to concede that it is therefore appropriate for anyone to treat us now, as if we already were dead. Further, it should be noted that the reader and I have this potential with far greater certainty than does the human embryo have the potential to become a glorious, sophisticated adult member of the human species. The scope of potential for personhood. The second difficulty with the potentiality argument involves the scope of the potential for personhood. If the human zygote has the potential to become an adult human being and is supposedly morally important in virtue of that potential, then what of the potential to become a zygote? Something has the potential to become a zygote, and whatever has the potential to become the zygote has whatever potential the zygote has. It follows that the unfertilized egg and the sperm, taken together, but as yet un-united, also have the potential to become fully functioning adult humans. It is sometimes objected that the individual sperm that will fertilize the egg is not identifiable in advance of conception. I am not sure why this is an objection, and it is true that in normal reproduction the identity of the sperm that will successfully fertilize the egg is unpredictable. But the identity of the sperm is not necessarily opaque. The technique known as ICSI (Intra Cytoplasmic Sperm Injection) does identify the individual sperm prior to fertilization. In addition, it is theoretically possible to stimulate eggs, including human eggs, to divide and develop without fertilization (parthenogenesis). As yet it has not been possible to continue the development process artificially beyond early stages of embryogenesis, but if it becomes possible then unfertilized eggs themselves, without need of sperm or cloning (see below), also would have the potential of the zygote. Finally, cloning by nuclear transfer, which involves deleting the nucleus of an unfertilized egg, inserting the nucleus taken from any adult cell, and electrically stimulating the resulting newly created egg to develop, can, in theory, produce a new human. This means that any cell from a normal human body has the potential to become a new "twin" of that individual. All that is needed is an appropriate environment and appropriate stimulation. But this of course is true of normal reproduction. The zygote only has the potential to become an adult member of the species if placed in the appropriate environment and treated thereafter in appropriate and complex ways. The techniques of parthenogenesis and cloning by nuclear substitution mean that conception is no longer the necessary precursor of human beings. [End Page 298] Thus if the argument from potential is understood to afford protection and moral status to whatever has the potential to grow into a normal adult human being, then potentially every human cell deserves protection. I shall not be concerned to refute such an ethic here, but will simply note that it is a very exhausting ethic. What is important about potential? The account of potentiality given here and elsewhere has been criticized for its simplicity. John Finnis (1995, p. 50), for example, has argued that: "[a]n organic capacity for developing eye-sight is not 'the bare fact that something will become' sighted; it is an existing reality, a thoroughly unitary ensemble of dynamically inter-related primordia of, bases and structures for, development." He concludes that "there is no sense whatever in which the unfertilized ovum and that sperm constitute one organism, a dynamic unity, identity, whole." On the other hand, the account of potential I have outlined treats potentiality as a rather more straightforward idea. A has the potential for Z if, when a certain number of things do and do not happen to A (or to A plus N), then A or A plus N will become Z. For even a "unitary ensemble of dynamically inter-related primordia of, bases and structures for development" must have a certain number of things happen to it and a certain number of things that do not happen to it if its potential is to be actualized. If this monstrous beast of Finnis's is a zygote, it must implant, be nourished, and have a genetic constitution compatible with survival to term and beyond. Why, the list of things that must happen in normal reproduction, should not also include fertilization is unclear to me. Moreover Finnis's insistence on a "unitary ensemble," on "one organism," seems vulnerable to cloning by nuclear substitution. For any of Finnis's skin cells, if treated appropriately, might be cloned. As Julian Savulescu (1999, p. 91) has recently reminded us, "What happens when a skin cell turns into a totipotent stem cell is that a few of its genetic switches are turned on and others are turned off. To say it doesn't have the potential to be a human being until its nucleus is placed in the egg cytoplasm is like saying my car does not have the potential to get me from Melbourne to Sydney unless the key is turned in the ignition." Most importantly, however, Finnis's objections, and those of a similar kind, miss the main point of the argument from potential. The potentiality of something, or some things, has moral importance on the assumption [End Page 299] that actualizing a particular potential is what matters. We would not worry about what precisely it is that has the potential to be a person, or an adult human being, if persons or adult humans did not matter. We are only interested in the potentiality argument because we are interested in the potential to become a particular, and particularly valuable, sort of thing. If, as I suggested above, the zygote (Finnis's unitary ensemble) is important because it has the potential for personhood, and that is what makes it a matter of importance to protect and actualize its potential; then whatever has the potential to become a zygote must also be morally significant for the same reason. Those with their "eyes on the prize," value potentiality for personhood, not because the potential is contained within "one organism," but because it is the potential to become something the actualisation of which has moral importance. Gradualism Another approach to the question of when human life becomes morally important is the gradualist approach to moral status. It is suggested that since we know that a morally important person will almost certainly, eventually emerge, it is appropriate to accord a gradually increasing moral status to the embryo or fetus. This view is attractive and has about it the classic air of political compromise. However, if we know why, in virtue of what, it is that normal human adults possess personhood, then we will in principle be able to gauge more precisely when these features, whatever they are, might with some plausibility be said to be present in the emerging individual. Furthermore, if, as I suggest later, personhood turns out to be a threshold concept, then proximity to the threshold is unimportant compared with the importance of crossing it, and there is no justification for taking a gradualist approach to personhood or moral status. Brain Birth Finally, Michael Lockwood (1988) has suggested an elegant solution to the problem of when morally important life begins. Noting that "brain death" is an almost universally accepted criterion of death, and hence of the termination of the moral status of the individual, he has proposed that "brain birth" might be a sensible point at which to date the genesis of moral status. The problem is that "brain death," although almost universally accepted as a criterion of death, seems less acceptable as a criterion of loss of moral status. Discussion of why this is so is postponed, [End Page 300] however, until the consideration of a case of persistent vegetative state in the penultimate section of this paper. The Meaning of Life Let us step aside for a moment from the previous concerns and consider the question "what is the meaning of life?" rather than "what is

it that gives moral status or ultimate value to life?" Philosophers, of this century at least, have generally shied away from this sort of question, except, that is, for the distinguished and much underrated Douglas Adams. In his seminal trilogy, "The Hitchhiker's Guide to the Galaxy," Adams (1972, Ch. 27) conducted a famous thought experiment. He imagined a race of beings that wished to solve the ultimate question, the question of the meaning of "life, the universe and everything," and to this end constructed a hyper-intelligent computer to solve the problem. After seven and a half million years, the computer came back with the answer "42." This answer is illuminating in an interesting way. Clearly it seems unsatisfactory as an answer to the question: "What is the meaning of life, the universe and everything?" However, the problem with criticizing the answer is that we have not the most rudimentary of idea of what a more plausible (less outrageous) answer might look like. We seem to lack a perspective from which to criticize any answer offered. Nonhuman Persons If we

turn now from this question of the meaning of life to questions of its value and ultimate status, things are rather different. Here we do seem to have a perspective, not only from which to criticize possible answers to the question, but from which to construct our own answer. Consider the question of whether there are persons on other planets. Although we do not know the answer to this question, we do know what would convince us that we had found an affirmative answer. We have, in the back of our minds at least, an idea of what we are looking for when we look for people, or evidence of people, on other planets. Let us be clear, however, about what we are *not* looking for. First, we are not looking exclusively or primarily, for human beings. We do not expect persons on other planets, if there are any, necessarily to be members of our own species. Second, we are not necessarily even looking for organic life forms, it may be that we will become convinced that self-constructing machines of sufficient intelligence would count as persons. Third, we are not looking for nonpersonal life forms, although we may also find these and be excited if we do. Neither are we looking for the sort of machinery that would not count as a person (perhaps machinery left behind by persons long since deceased). These observations show us that we do not, in fact, regard species membership as hugely significant in trying to understand what a person might be. Nor even do we require that persons be organic life forms. What then are we looking for? What should convince us that we had discovered persons on other planets? Suppose, that instead of us discovering persons on other planets, they discovered us. Demonstrating their vastly superior technology by arriving on Earth having traversed unimaginable interstellar distances, the extraterrestrials are hungry and tired after their long journey. What could we point to about ourselves that ought to convince the extra-terrestrials that they had discovered persons, morally significant beings of special importance, on another planet? What could we say of ourselves that should convince them of the appropriateness of "having us for dinner" in one sense rather than another? What should convince them to treat us as dinner guests rather than the dinner itself? What makes for a moral distinction between ourselves and, say, lettuces or turnips? Toward the end of the seventeenth century in his "Essay Concerning Human Understanding" the philosopher John Locke attempted to answer this question in a way that has scarcely been surpassed. He wrote: We must consider what person stands for: which I think is a thinking intelligent being, that has reason and reflection, and can consider itself the same thinking thing, in different times and places: which it does only by that consciousness which is inseparable from thinking and seems to me essential to it; it being impossible for anyone to perceive without perceiving that he does perceive. (Locke 1690, Ch. 27, Book II, p. 188) It seems to me that it is beings possessing these capacities, or something closely akin to them, that we are looking for when we ask the question "Are there persons on other planets?" And we must hope that if it is others of vastly superior technology that are asking the question, that they recognize in us fellow creatures of moral standing, fellow persons. It is a species-neutral description but it identifies those features, the potential for which is so important to the failed potentiality argument and the presence of which in space creatures should surely convince us that we had at last encountered persons elsewhere in the universe.

AGI

Extinction is a decision rule – it solves future generations of nonhuman suffering.

Sittler-Adamczewski 16 [Thomas; December; University of Oxford; Journal of Practical Ethics, "Consistent Vegetarianism and the Suffering of Wild Animals," <http://www.jpe.ox.ac.uk/papers/consistent-vegetarianism-and-the-suffering-of-wild-animals/>]

If animals like free-range cows have lives that are not worth living, almost all wild animals could plausibly be thought to also have lives that are worse than non-existence. Nature is often romanticised as a well-balanced idyll, so this may seem counter-intuitive. But extreme forms of suffering like starvation, dehydration, or being eaten alive by a predator are much more common in wild animals than farm animals. Crocodiles and hyenas disembowel their prey before killing them (Tomasik 2009). In birds, diseases like avian salmonellosis produce excruciating symptoms in the final days of life, such as depression, shivering, loss of appetite, and just before death, blindness, incoordination, staggering, tremor and convulsions (Michigan Department of Natural Resources). While a farmed animal like a free-range cow has to endure some confinement and a premature and potentially painful death (stunning sometimes fails), a wild animal may suffer comparable experiences, such as surviving a cold winter or having to fear predators, while additionally undergoing the aforementioned extreme suffering (Tomasik 2013). Wild animals do experience significant pleasure, for instance when they eat, play, have sex, or engage in other normal physical activity. One reason to suspect that on average this pleasure is outweighed by suffering is that most species use the reproductive strategy of r-selection, which means that the overwhelming majority of their offspring starve or are eaten shortly after birth and only very few reach reproductive age (Horta 2010; Ng 1995). For instance, 'in her lifetime a lioness might have 20 cubs; a pigeon, 150 chicks; a mouse, 1000 kits' (Hapgood 1979), the vast majority of which will die before they could have had many pleasurable experiences. Overall, it seems plausible that wild animals have worse lives than, say, free-range cows. If vegetarians think it's better for the latter not to exist, they must believe the same thing about wild animals.

A second important empirical fact is that wild animals far outnumber farmed animals. Using figures from the FAO, Tomasik estimates that the global livestock population is 24 billion (including 17 billion chicken) (Tomasik 2014). I restrict my count of wild animals to those at least as complex as chicken or small fish, which vegetarians clearly believe do have moral weight. Using studies of animal density in different biomes, Tomasik estimates conservatively that there are at least 6×10^{10} land birds, 10^{11} land mammals, and 10^{13} fish. Animals in each of these categories alone are several times more numerous than livestock.

If wild animals' well-being is indeed below the threshold for a life worth living, and the above numbers are remotely correct, the scale of wild animal suffering is vast. As Richard Dawkins writes, 'During the minute it takes me to compose this sentence, thousands of animals are being eaten alive; others are running for their lives, whimpering with fear; others are being slowly devoured from within by rasping parasites; thousands of all kinds are dying of starvation, thirst and disease.' (Dawkins 1996) If they accept the premises so far, consistent vegetarians should focus on preventing the existence of as many wild animals as possible, since even a small reduction in the global number of wild animals would outweigh the impact of ending all livestock production. For example, they could reduce animal populations by sterilising them, or by destroying highly dense animal habitats such as rainforests. It may even be the case that vegetarians should react to this argument by eating more meat, since feeding livestock requires more surface area for agriculture, and fields contain far fewer wild animals per square kilometre than other biomes such as forests (Matheny and Chan 2005, 585). Of course, to the extent that it is more difficult to reduce wild animal populations than farm animal populations, vegetarians should focus more resources on the latter. But it seems implausible that it would be over a hundred times more difficult to achieve the same proportional reduction, which is what would be needed to reverse my conclusion that wild animal suffering dominates. There could be some simple ways, for instance, for vegetarians to reduce habitat sizes: supporting the construction of large parking lots, or donating to a pro-deforestation lobby. In the final paragraph, I touch upon the issue of how most effectively to reduce wild animal suffering.

Non-human suffering is the largest impact---in quantity and severity.

Moen '16 [Ole Martin; 2016; University of Oslo, Centre for the Study of Mind in Nature; Nord J Appl Ethics, "ethics of wild animal suffering,"
<http://www.olemartinmoen.com/wp-content/uploads/TheEthicsofWildAnimalSuffering.pdf>]

Although solipsism at the species level might make sense within religious contexts where humans are taken to have originated separately from all other animals, it coheres well with neither neuroscience nor evolution. Comparing ourselves to sparrows, rabbits, and bears, we may observe that we have the same kind of neurons, the same main brain parts, and the same pain pathways (C and A delta fibers) that they have. Sparrows, rabbits, and bears, moreover, react to noxious stimuli the same way we do, and they stop doing so when anesthetized (see Griffin & Speck 2004; Dawkins 2015). Since we and other animals are genetically, neurologically, and functionally very close, we would need weighty evidence to conclude that, despite these similarities,

humans work in fundamentally different ways from other animals: humans consciously, animals non-consciously.¹

Increased understanding of animal consciousness helped spur the animal ethics movement. Keeping animals in small cages, castrating them without anesthetics, and branding them with glowing irons—practices that, if performed on humans, would land the perpetrator in prison for decades—are common farming practices around the world. Millions of farm animals live and die under such conditions. Opposing human disregard for animal welfare, Peter Singer (1990) famously argues that just as we have gradually expanded our circle of moral concern to encompass ethnic groups other than our own, and finally humanity as a whole, we should further expand it to include other sentient species. According to Singer, it is suffering as such that is bad, and it is bad whoever experiences it.

Though the animal ethics movement is commendable, its circle of moral concern has hitherto expanded almost exclusively to captive animals. With very few exceptions—most notably, David Pearce and Jeff McMahan, whom I shall discuss in detail below—animal ethicists have failed to adequately take into account the suffering of animals living in the wild. Wild animals, however, vastly outnumber captive animals, and arguably, billions of wild animals live lives that are even more painful and distressing than those of their captive counterparts. Though it might well be difficult to alleviate suffering in the wild, and comparatively easier to alleviate suffering caused by humans, disregarding wild animal suffering from the outset involves a form of anthropocentrism that, sadly, enjoys wide acceptance even among those who purport to oppose the doctrine. We might dub this the second anthropocentrism. While traditional anthropocentrists are concerned only with human suffering, anthropocentrists of the second kind are concerned only with human-caused suffering. I will suggest, however, that if we take suffering as such to be bad (roughly along the lines that Singer does), it is unclear why the species membership of those who cause the suffering is morally relevant while the species membership of those who suffer is not.

My aim in this paper is not to sway those who are indifferent to animal welfare. Rather, my aim is to make those who are concerned with animal welfare more concerned with the welfare of wild animals. Moreover, I shall exclusively discuss welfarist concerns, so if there are other grounds to care for animals, they lie beyond the scope of this paper. My discussion is limited to mammals and birds, the reason for which is that these are the animals whose ability to suffer is least disputed. If fish, amphibians, reptiles, and/or invertebrates can also suffer, my conclusion is amplified.

The empirical side

Let me start by defending three empirical claims: (1) that there are vastly more wild than captive animals; (2) that wild animals have the same capacity to suffer as captive animals; and (3) that many, perhaps most, wild animals suffer at least as much as their captive counterparts. These are all empirical claims that say nothing about the value significance of wild animal suffering. As such, we should accept or reject these claims irrespective of our ethical views.

How many captive animals are there? According to the Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations (2014), the total number of livestock in the world is—at any given time—roughly 25 billion, the majority of which are chicken, followed by ducks, cattle, and sheep. Although this figure leaves out pets and laboratory animals, let us take for granted, for the sake of convenience, that the number of livestock is roughly representative of the number of captive animals.

How many wild animals are there? According to Brian Tomasik's (2014a) estimations, which are generated from research data on the typical prevalence of various animals in various environments coupled with data on the global prevalence of these environments, there are—at any given time—between 60 and 200 billion birds and between 100 and 1,000 billion mammals. If we assume the middle estimate for both birds and mammals, there are, at any given time, 700 billion wild birds and wild mammals combined. This is roughly 25 times the number of birds and mammals in captivity. (If we were to include in our estimates fish, amphibians, reptiles, and invertebrates, which are rare in human captivity but very prevalent in the wild, we would end up with thousands of times more wild than captive animals.)

A further empirical premise is that wild animals have the same ability to suffer as captive animals. By this I simply mean that if you tear the skin of both a wild and a captive animal, there is no compelling reason to believe that this would hurt more for the captive animal than for the wild animal. In fact, if we were to conclude that there is a difference between the two, we should probably conclude that while captive animals are more docile (due to drugs and lack of stimulation), wild animals remain sharp and focused. Let us assume, however, that the ability to suffer is the same, or roughly the same, in captive and wild animals.

How much do wild animals actually suffer? Very likely, some wild animals suffer very little. Some live long and peaceful lives, have few natural enemies, and have ample supplies of food. When they die, moreover, many animals die quick and painless deaths.

The fact that some lives in the wild are pleasant, however, does not contradict the fact **for billions of wild animals, life is filled with suffering**. One prominent source of suffering is predation. Every day, millions of animals are eaten alive, and though some of them are killed quickly, larger animals will often stay alive for minutes or hours before they die of blood loss, suffocation, drowning, or internal bleeding from poisoning (Tomasik 2014b). While some become paralyzed, and are likely to feel nothing, others feel excruciating pain.

Predation is a very visible cause of suffering. In response to this, Tyler Cowen (2003) and Jeff McMahan (2010) have argued that if we can easily prevent a predator attack, we have at least a pro tanto moral reason to do so. In their view, the way predators kill their prey is often so

gruesome that if a human were to treat animals similarly, we would have strong reasons to intervene – and for the animal that is eaten alive, the species membership of the attacking predator is likely to matter very little.

Though this is an important observation, I think Cowen and McMahan fail to appreciate that suffering caused by predation is likely to account for only a small fraction of the total suffering in nature. Though death from predation might be the most violent and visible cause of suffering, deaths from disease and parasites tend to be more drawn out in time. The same is true of deaths from droughts, floods, and freezing. Life in the wild is also a constant quest for nutrition; **at any given time, thousands of animals are** in the process of **starving to death**. Though there is no agent responsible for this suffering, and though it might be hard for us to detect it, the **suffering is nonetheless real and prevalent**.

When a parent animal starves or freezes to death, gets eaten, or dies from disease, its young offspring will often face an equally painful death. This borders on an important point, namely that most suffering in nature is likely to be endured by very young individuals. The reason is not primarily that many parent animals die (although that is also the case), but that most wild animals give birth to many more offspring than are likely to reach adulthood. While humans normally give birth to just one child per year, and provide extensive care to each child (this is called the Kselection strategy), many **animals follow** a different reproductive strategy: they give birth to dozens or hundreds of offspring every year, and care very little for each individual (**the r-selection strategy**). These strategies both work to spread the parents' genes in the population, but the r-selection strategy—which is most common in smaller animals—**leads to enormous amounts of suffering** because of the very **large number of** young **individuals that are left to starve to death or get eaten**, either by their stronger siblings or by other predators (for an elaboration, see Horta 2010). If the average female in a given animal population gives birth to 50 offspring every year—and the population size remains stable year after year—then the majority of individuals in that population will be individuals dying before reaching adulthood. If we grant that animals become conscious shortly after birth, as we assume to be the case with humans, their **deaths will** often **involve pain**, and since their lives are very short, they will **have very few good things** in life **to weigh up for all that is bad**.

For these reasons, Richard Dawkins is almost certainly correct when he writes:

The total amount of suffering per year in the natural world is beyond all decent contemplation. During the minute that it takes me to compose this sentence, thousands of animals are being eaten alive, others are running for their lives, whimpering with fear, others are being slowly devoured from within by rasping parasites, thousands of all kinds are dying of starvation, thirst and disease (Dawkins 1995: 131-32).

Wild animal suffering is mostly **invisible to us**. Humans never see the vast majority of wild animals, and those that are seen by us are predominantly healthy and moving. We **do not see the young individuals starving to death or the adult individuals being devoured by parasites**, and we must keep in mind that even if we saw them, their

suffering would often not be apparent to us. While we have evolved to pick up pain cues from other human beings, we are much worse at picking up pain cues from non-human animals, especially those that are genetically remote from us. Moreover, many animals hide signs of weakness and disease to avoid attracting predators (including humans) looking for easy prey.

When Thomas Hobbes wrote that life, in the state of nature, is “solitary, poor, nasty, brutish, and short,” he meant human life (Hobbes 1651/1996: XIII.9). It seems, however, that the description is also fitting for the lives of many non-human animals.

Because of the brutality of wildlife, one could even make the provocative case that a typical life in the wild is even more painful and distressing than a typical life in human captivity. Although factory farming is often grotesque, animals in captivity are seldom killed in ways that draw out their deaths over several minutes or hours; they are not exposed to predators until they are slaughtered; they typically have access to sufficient amounts of food and water; and the temperature tends to be comfortable. Concerning larger animals, such as cattle, individuals with serious diseases will often be euthanized. For this reason, it is not clear that the average life in the wild is filled with any less suffering than the average life in captivity. However, even if wild animals do, on average, suffer less than captive animals, the sheer number of wild animals is still so overwhelming that the majority of suffering on Earth almost certainly takes place among animals living in wild nature.

High level research proves.

Nussbaum '23 [Martha; January 24; M.A. '71, Ph.D. '75; Harvard Gazette, “They can think, feel pain, love. Isn’t it time animals had rights?,”
<https://news.harvard.edu/gazette/story/2023/01/they-can-think-feel-pain-love-isnt-it-time-animals-had-rights/>]

Recent decades, however, have seen an explosion of high-level research covering all areas of the animal world. We now know more not only about animals long closely studied — primates and companion animals — but also about animals who are difficult to study — marine mammals, whales, fish, birds, reptiles, and cephalopods.

We know — not just by observation, but by carefully designed experimental work — that all vertebrates and many invertebrates feel pain subjectively, and have, more generally, a subjectively felt view of the world: the world looks like something to them. We know that all of these animals experience at least some emotions (fear being the most ubiquitous), and that many experience emotions like compassion and grief that involve more complex “takes” on a situation. We know that animals as different as dolphins and crows can solve complicated problems and learn to use tools to solve them. We know that animals have complex forms of social organization and social behavior. More recently, we have been learning that these social groups are not simply places where a rote inherited repertory is acted out, but places of complicated social learning. Species as different as whales, dogs, and many types of birds clearly transmit key parts of the species’ repertoire to their young socially, not just genetically.

What are the implications of this research for ethics? Huge, clearly. We can no longer draw the usual line between our own species and “the beasts,” a line meant to distinguish intelligence, emotion, and sentience from the dense life of a “brute beast.” Nor can we even draw a line between a group of animals we already recognize as sort of “like us” — apes, elephants, whales, dogs — and others who are supposed to be unintelligent. Intelligence takes multiple and fascinating forms in the real world, and birds, evolving by a very different path from humans, have converged on many similar abilities. Even an invertebrate such as the octopus has surprising capacities for intelligent perception: an octopus can recognize individual humans, and can solve complex problems, guiding one of its arms through a maze to obtain food using only its eyes. Once we recognize all this we can hardly be unchanged in our ethical thinking. To put a “brute beast” in a cage seems no more wrong than putting a rock in a terrarium. But that is not what we are doing. We are deforming the existence of intelligent and complexly sentient forms of life. Each of these animals strives for a flourishing life, and each has abilities, social

and individual, that equip it to negotiate a decent life in a world that gives animals **difficult challenges**. **What humans are doing is** to thwart this striving — and this seems **wrong**.

Evolutionary R-Selection guarantees net animal suffering; the vast majority of animals suffer painful death shortly after birth, so value to life can't possibly outweigh.

Tomasik '17 [Brian; February; consultant for the Foundational Research Institute; former tech developer and programmer at Microsoft; member of 80,000 Hours charity of Oxford University; Board member @ Animal Charity Evaluators; studied computer science, mathematics, statistics, and economics at Swarthmore College; "The Importance of Wild-Animal Suffering," <http://www.utilitarian-essays.com/suffering-nature.html>]

This strategy of "making lots of copies and hoping a few come out" may be perfectly sensible from the standpoint of evolution, but the **cost to the individual organisms is tremendous**. Matthew Clarke and Yew-Kwang Ng conclude from an analysis of the welfare implications of population dynamics that "The **number of offspring** of a species **that maximizes fitness** may **lead to suffering** and is different from the number that maximizes welfare (average or total)."[ClarkeNg, sec. 4]

In a related paper, "Towards Welfare Biology: Evolutionary Economics of Animal Consciousness and Suffering," Ng concludes from the excess of offspring over adult survivors: "Under the assumptions of concave and symmetrical functions relating costs to enjoyment and suffering, **evolutionary economizing results in the excess of total suffering over total enjoyment**." [Ng, p. 272]

In his famous paper, "Animal liberation and environmental ethics: Bad marriage, quick divorce," [Sagoff] Mark Sagoff quotes the following passage from Fred Hapgood: [Hapgood]

All species reproduce in excess, way past the carrying capacity of their niche. In her lifetime a lioness might have 20 cubs; a pigeon, 150 chicks; a mouse, 1000 kits; a trout, 20,000 fry, a tuna or cod, a million fry or more; [...] and an oyster, perhaps a hundred million spat. If one assumes that the population of each of these species is, from generation to generation, roughly equal, then on average only one offspring will survive to replace each parent. All the other **thousands and millions will die**, one way or another.¹

Sagoff goes on to say: "The **misery of animals in nature**—which humans can do much to relieve—**makes every other form of**

suffering pale in comparison. Mother Nature is so cruel to her children she makes Frank Perdue look like a saint."